PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #64 · ABUSE

"I don't deserve to be safe or treated kindly."

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Where it often comes from

Harm can teach a person that safety and kindness are for other people. If you were not protected, it is easy to decide you did not deserve protection. That is the lie. Safety is not a wage. Kindness is not something you qualify for by being unhurt or by being perfect. You are allowed to want safety, to ask for it, and to leave what is unsafe. You do not have to explain why you are worth protecting. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

God is a refuge and strength, an ever-present help. That help is not issued to the people who earned a safe life. "Do not fear, for I am with you." He cares for you, and you can cast anxiety on Him. He is near the brokenhearted. He will not forsake you. None of these verses say, "If you had deserved it, you would have been safe." They say He is a refuge for people in trouble.

> *"God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble"* (Psalm 46:1).

Also see

> "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness" (Isaiah 41:10).

> "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you" (1 Peter 5:7).

> "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit" (Psalm 34:18).

> "The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged" (Deuteronomy 31:8).

Common self-statements

- I probably deserved it.
- Safe homes are for other kinds of people.
- If I ask for kindness, I am being greedy.
- I should be grateful it was not worse.
- Protecting myself would hurt them, so I should not.
- God helps people who deserve it. I do not.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Deciding harm means you were unworthy of safety.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling undeserving and calling that God's view.
- Discounting the positive: Treating every offer of safety as something you should refuse.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If life has been unsafe, you are not allowed to seek safety now.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that I had to earn safety?

- Would I tell a child they did not deserve to be safe?
- What would I do for a friend in my situation?
- Is staying a choice, or a rule that says I do not count?
- What does "God is our refuge" offer to someone who feels undeserving?
- What is one step toward safety I can take with a counselor or a hotline, not alone?

Truth summary

> I deserve to be safe and treated kindly. Safety is not something I have to earn, and what was done to me did not remove my right to it.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Trust
- Peace
- Love, By God
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Trouble/Hardship
- Love

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
You are allowed to be held. Safety is not a prize you earn.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
A hurting soul can hope for safety without having to deserve it first.

Worn — Tenth Avenue North
Being worn down is not a reason you should stay unsafe.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
You belong to Christ. Safety and kindness are not rewards for being unharmed.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I don't deserve to be safe or treated kindly."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I don't deserve to be safe or treated kindly." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me that I had to earn safety?
- ☐ Would I tell a child they did not deserve to be safe?
- ☐ What would I do for a friend in my situation?
- ☐ Is staying a choice, or a rule that says I do not count?
- ☐ What does "God is our refuge" offer to someone who feels undeserving?
- ☐ What is one step toward safety I can take with a counselor or a hotline, not alone?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I deserve to be safe and treated kindly. Safety is not something I have to earn, and what was done to me did not remove my right to it.
- ☐ Safety is not a reward.
- ☐ I am allowed to want kindness.
- ☐ What was done to me did not make me undeserving.
- ☐ God is a refuge for people in trouble, including me.
- ☐ I can ask for protection without making a case for my worth.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 46:1
  "God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ 1 Peter 5:7
  "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When you felt you did not deserve safety: Each day, write down one moment when kindness or protection felt like too much to ask. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 46:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God is a refuge for me. I do not have to earn the right to be safe.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.

- ☐ Say the sentence aloud: "I am allowed to be safe." Notice the argument that follows, and do not obey it.
- ☐ Make one safety contact if you are not safe: 911, or 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call 1-800-422-4453.
- ☐ Accept one kindness this week without apologizing for needing it.
- ☐ Plan with your counselor one boundary or exit step. Do not do a dangerous step alone.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I don't deserve to be safe or treated kindly.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step I took toward safety
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I don't deserve to be safe or treated kindly~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have believed I do not deserve safety or kindness. You are a refuge. Teach me that protection is not a prize, and give me courage to reach for help. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.